



Renewed purpose: Dharmaraj Solairaj, who lost his left leg during service, now competes for India in the men's long jump T64 category.

Someswararao, like Solairaj, served in the Madras Regiment and was fluent in Tamil. He had lost a limb to a mine blast while on patrol in Uri, Jammu, in 2014.

Solairaj spoke to him about his life, his love for sport growing up in Tuticorin, the injury, and his fear of whether he would ever walk again or what his life might look like now. He was hoping for consolation. What he received instead was a dose of dark humour.

"Looks like your leg's coming off tomorrow. You probably should be enjoying your last day with it and then start saying your goodbyes! But once it's gone, you should give me a call. I'm an athlete at the Army Para Sports Node. I think you will be great for the Paralympic Node we have got," Someswararao told him.

He followed it up with reassurance. "Don't worry. You won't just walk, I promise you will be running!" he says.

After the initial shock of Someswararao's bluntness wore off,

Solairaj recalls feeling hopeful for the first time. "Seeing him walk around so confidently without a leg, just in his shorts, was a big motivation for me. My biggest concern was that I wouldn't be able to walk again. When Rao *saab* told me, 'You aren't just going to walk, you are going to fly,' I felt that maybe things wouldn't be that bad," he tells *Sportstar*.

Someswararao's words would prove prophetic.

Solairaj learned to walk again, first on a prosthetic leg. The following year, he joined the Army Paralympic Node, where he was fitted with a running blade and learned to run and then jump on it.

His record now speaks for itself.

Big ambitions

Solairaj is not the only standout athlete at the Node. Today, the Army Paralympic Node is a hive of activity. At the Army Sports Institute in Pune, runners and jumpers train on the track or lift heavy weights in the gym. A few miles away, at Training Battalion 2 of the Bombay Sappers, where the Node is headquartered, throwers and archers hone their craft. Rowers train at the Army Rowing Node in Pune, kayakers take to the water in Bhopal, shooters

practise at the Army Marksmanship Unit in Mhow, while a small taekwondo contingent trains at the Army Taekwondo Node in Bengaluru.

At present, 55 soldiers-turned-athletes are chasing elite sporting careers at the Paralympic Node. The results suggest progress. At the 2023 Asian Para Games in Hangzhou, the contingent won seven medals, including gold for Solairaj. In Paris 2024, Subedar Hokato Sema claimed the first-ever Paralympic medal for the Node with bronze in Men's Shot Put F57. Two months ago, two athletes from the Node won medals at the World Para Athletics Championships. In all, Army Para athletes have won 230 medals at the national level and 123 internationally.

Even that is not enough. "We are still a relatively young organisation, but we are improving rapidly," says Lt Col Nitten Mehta, the current head of the Army Paralympic Node. "At the World Championships in athletics, we were only behind Uttar Pradesh and Haryana as an organisation. We have won medals at World Para Shooting and World Para Rowing Cups. We won our first Paralympic medal in 2024, and we have much bigger ambitions for the 2028 Paralympics. We started with five sports and have since added four more, specifically triathlon, climbing, canoeing and kayaking, and taekwondo, because these are medal events at Los Angeles," he says.

Humble start

Ambitious as their goals are, the idea of a para sports node itself was once equally bold.

Before the Node formally opened in 2017, there was no structured para sports programme within the Indian Army. "There were injured soldiers who took part in sports. We even had a Blade Runner in Anandan Gunasekaran, but all of them trained on their own initiative," says Colonel Gaurav Dutta, who founded the Node. Dutta was one of them. As a young officer, he lost part of his right leg to a mine blast in 2001 but taught himself to play competitive sport on an artificial limb. In 2009, he and a